



KHT SCHOOL LEARNING PACK

Building Better Communities in
Northern Thailand



www.karenhilltribes.org.uk



karenhilltribes



TheKarenHilltribesTrust



The Karen Hilltribes Trust



ABOUT KHT

The Karen Hilltribes Trust (KHT) is a British charity that has worked with the Karen people living in Northern Thailand for over three decades. As a community-led organisation, we partner with rural Karen communities to create sustainable solutions to improve community health, secure livelihoods and increase access to education.

Our goals are:

- Enhance community health by improving sanitation, hygiene, and access to safe water
- Secure sustainable livelihoods through increased food security and income generation
- Increase access to education for children and young adults to improve their opportunities





LEARNING THROUGH INDIGENOUS COMMUNITIES



The Karen are Thailand's largest indigenous ethnic minority. They have not benefitted from Thailand's economic growth and still face poverty and disadvantages.

The definition of poverty in the [English Oxford Dictionary] is 'the state of being extremely poor'.

But what does it mean to be extremely poor?

In Mae Hong Son province, northern Thailand, we believe there are four dimensions of extreme poverty:

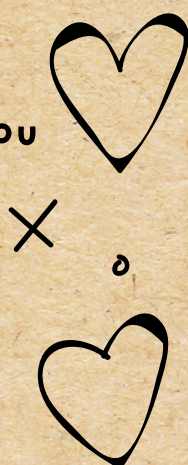
- Lack of access to basic rights and services (water and sanitation, livelihoods and education)
- Extreme marginalisation and physical isolation from wider society
- Discrimination against ethnic minorities and rural communities
- Vulnerability to extreme weather conditions and climate change

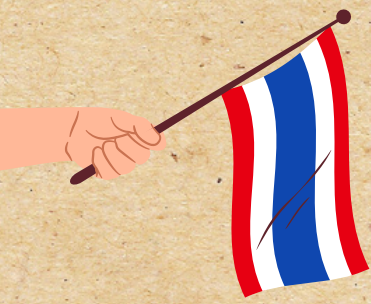
The Karen are in vital need of support, and this support needs to be sustainable, appropriate and effective. KHT aims to ensure our programmes work for the well being of the Karen and we need the help of organisations and individuals to do this. Together we can break the vicious cycle of poverty for a forgotten and marginalised community!

In this pack, you'll find lots of information, stories and handy tips and tools to increase your knowledge about the Karen, what's needed most and what you can do to support them!



Summereen
Director of
KHT





Indigenous communities across the world are facing challenges and struggles. They are often denied basic human rights and denied their voice. Indigenous communities are vital to the well-being of the planet and we have much to learn from them. The Karen have a fascinating history and culture, as well as meaningful traditions, language and beliefs.

COMMUNITY

Karen families are cross-generational, often with grandparents, parents and children living together under the same roof. The Karen people have few possessions and usually sleep on mats on the floor. Cooking is over an open fire on earth or the wooden floors of the house.

CULTURE

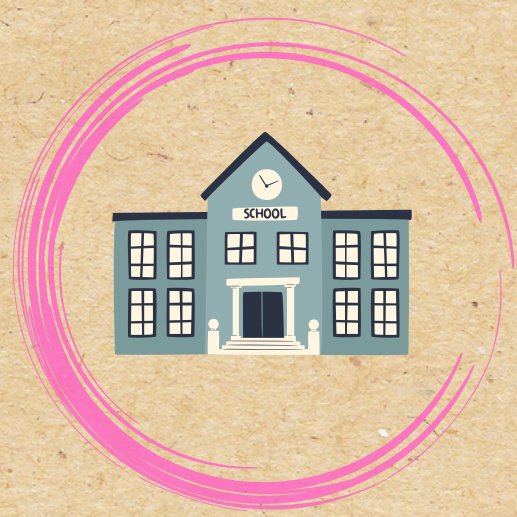
Whilst Thailand is predominantly a Buddhist country, the Karen are Animist, Buddhist and 30% Christian. The Karen make their own costumes and shoulder bags which are hand woven by the women sitting on the ground using a traditional strap loom.

ENVIRONMENT

The Karen people live within dense forests filled with teak and other tropical plant species. There are hundreds of villages tucked away on the sides of the mountains, sometimes 90 kilometres from the nearest hospital or secondary school.



1ST CHALLENGE: GET TO SCHOOL

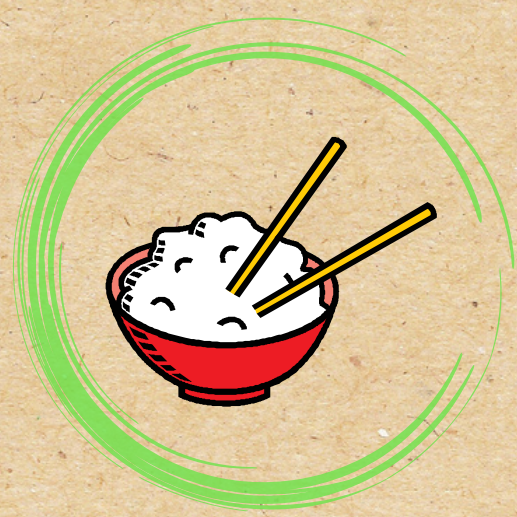


It can be very difficult for Karen communities to access education:

- Most villages within Mae Hong Son have a primary school within 10 kilometres of the village. However, secondary schools are limited to the larger towns and can be located up to 50 km away!
- Walking can be dangerous and therefore many parents keep their children at home, especially girls.
- The roads are often in poor condition and some villages have only dirt roads and are located far into the hills.
- Frequent rain and bad weather makes travel impossible and many children must live in dormitories away from home for much of the year.
- Missing out on education means Karen children have fewer opportunities and cannot improve their incomes and lives
- Lack of education harms the well being of girls and women who face additional burdens due to their gender



2ND CHALLENGE: GROW RICE

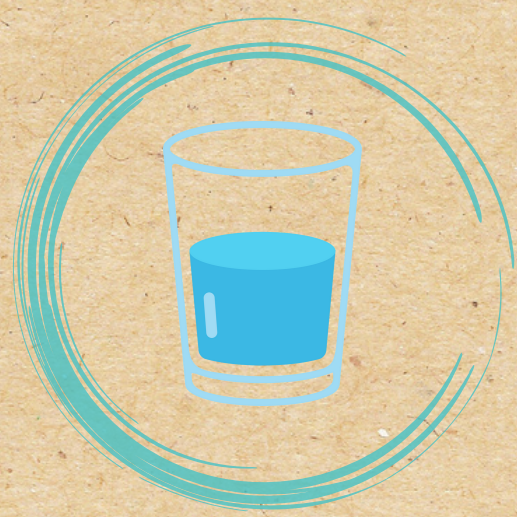


The Karen live in the remote mountainous areas of the province. A disproportionate majority of Karen communities depend on subsistence agriculture for their livelihoods, with an average annual income of just 24,500 THB (644 GBP) per household.



This high dependency on subsistence agriculture makes Karen communities extremely vulnerable to change in weather. Heavy rain can mean that crops get swept away, whilst the lack of rain can mean that the crops wither. Farmers are unable to use all their farmland and grow different crops to help food security and to sell for income. From KHT's research, it is clear that in most villages, at least 50% of villagers do not produce enough rice to last them through the year and most families suffer from food shortages at least five times a month.

3RD CHALLENGE: GET CLEAN WATER



One of the main reasons for poor health in Karen communities is through lack of access to adequate clean water, sanitation and hygiene (WASH) facilities. Around 40% of the population in Mae Hong Son lack access to clean drinking water and adequate waste disposal making. This makes them vulnerable to many diseases including diarrhea, typhoid, stomach ulcers and parasitic worms. Not only do these cause short-term health problems but they can also cause long-term chronic complications which have lasting impacts on health, education and livelihoods outcomes, helping continue the cycle of poverty.





OUR WORK



The provision of a school transport service is a simple solution to ensure access to education for Karen communities.



Through construction of flood-resistant irrigation systems (FRIS), the Irrigation Project strengthens agriculture as a sustainable livelihood for Karen farmers living in Mae Hong Son Province



We work with Karen communities to install innovative gravity-fed clean water systems, building and repairing sanitation units and providing hygiene education sessions.

For more info on KHT projects:
www.karenhilltribes.org.uk/our-work/



POVERTY: A BARRIER TO HEALTH AND HAPPINESS

Poverty is often a vicious cycle with multiple generations suffering. The Karen face different barriers to improving their lives, their health and their futures. These impact individuals and entire communities and have long term consequences for the Karen.

Supporting Ban Mae La Gnew Water and Help for Farmers



KHT is supporting the village of Ban Mae La Gnew with a WASH and Flood Resistant Irrigation System. KHT's help will ensure the village can grow rice again after years of unusable land and villagers will be able to access cleaner water without having to use dirty streams and or dig wells.

Mr Pathuhae is a resident in Mae La Gnew, where he lives with his wife. He has lived in the village since he was born and is a farmer. He was unable to attend school because there was no school, road or electricity when he was growing up.

For the farmers in the village, these last few years have been very difficult. There have been floods that have means they cannot grow rice. Without rice, the incomes in the village have lessened and poverty has increased.

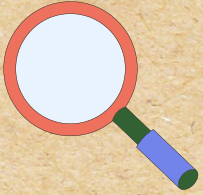
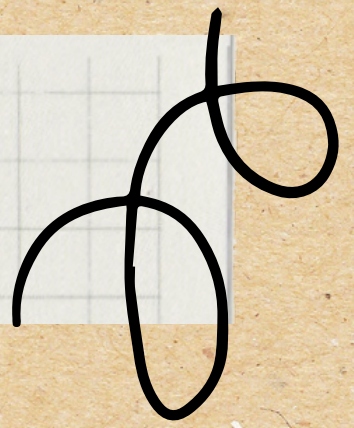
"We are so happy with your help. The villagers will now have water for drinking and using in our farming. It will help us live better lives.

As Karen we are given less opportunities because we are so far from everything, but you have come to help us."

Although the road to the village is still a dirt road and this makes it difficult for villagers to travel and access services, improving the crop diversity, health and income generation in the village will go a long way towards improving lives.



HOW YOU CAN HELP US



Get curious about the Karen and spread the knowledge

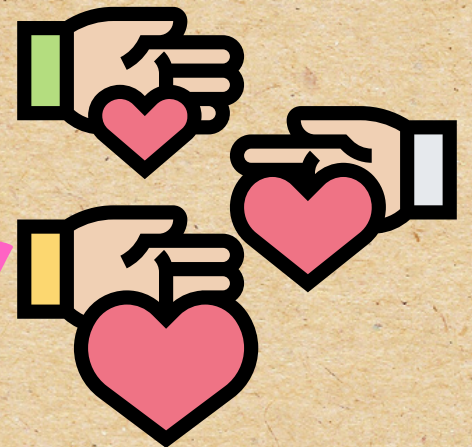
Organise talks and events to sensitise other people about the Karen marginalisation



Get involved, try KHT lab and be prepared to literally put yourself in the shoes of a Karen villager

Be creative and think of ways you could raise funds to support KHT projects!!!

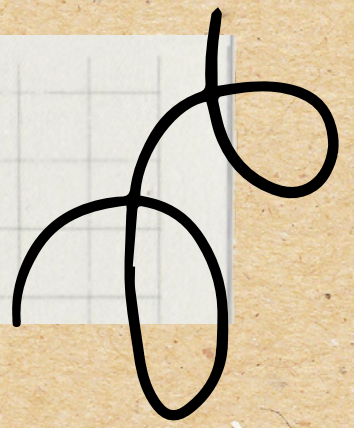
**Some ideas: Game Day – Sell your creations
– Treasure Hunt – Carol singing for
Christmas – School picnic in the community**



Launch a campaign and open a crowdfunding page, asking your friends and family members to get involved and help you reach your target!



HOW YOU CAN HELP US



ADOPT



A SCHOLAR:

10£ can give a karen student the energy to learn by providing a month of school meals and free and safe transport to and from school



A SCHOOL BUS

25£ helps one of our bus routes get children from remote villages to and from school all year round



A KAREN FARMER

35£ can contribute to the construction of a Flood Resistant Irrigation System, to reduce poverty and increase food security for the Karen villagers.



CLEAN WATER FOR A FAMILY

100£ can turn on the tap and provide a family with the gift of clean water.

TAKE A STEP FORWARD

ACTIVITY*



Overview

We are all equal, but some are more equal than others. In this activity participants take on roles and move forward depending on their chances and opportunities in life and they better understand how living as a Karen means.

Objectives

- To raise awareness about inequality of opportunity, especially for Karen people
- To develop imagination and critical thinking
- To foster empathy with others who are less fortunate

Materials

- Role cards
- An open space (a corridor, large room or outdoors)
- Tape or CD player and soft/relaxing music
- A hat



*Instructions for teachers

INSTRUCTIONS

ACTIVITY*

1. Create a calm atmosphere with some soft background music. Alternatively, ask the participants for silence.
2. Ask participants to take a role card out of the hat. Tell them to keep it to themselves and not to show it to anyone else.
3. Invite them to sit down (preferably on the floor) and to read carefully what is on their role card.
4. Now ask them to begin to get into role. To help, read out some of the following questions, pausing after each one, to give people time to reflect and build up a picture of themselves and their lives:
 - What was your childhood like? What sort of house did you live in? What kind of games did you play? What sort of work did your parents do?
 - What is your everyday life like now? Where do you socialise? What do you do in the morning, in the afternoon, in the evening?
 - What sort of lifestyle do you have? Where do you live? How much money do you earn each month? What do you do in your leisure time? What do you do in your holidays?
 - What excites you and what are you afraid of?
5. Now ask people to remain absolutely silent as they line up beside each other (like on a starting line)
6. Tell the participants that you are going to read out a list of situations or events. Every time that they can answer "yes" to the statement, they should take a step forward. Otherwise, they should stay where they are and not move.
7. Read out the situations one at a time. Pause for a while between each statement to allow people time to step forward and to look around to take note of their positions relative to each other.
8. At the end invite everyone to take note of their final positions. Then give them a couple of minutes to come out of role before debriefing in plenary.

*Instructions for teachers

ROLE CARDS

ACTIVITY*

You are the daughter/son of the local bank manager. You study Economics at university.	You are the 18-year-old son/daughter of a poor Karen farmer in a remote village in the mountains.
You are a disabled young man/woman living in a remote village in the mountains who can only move in a wheelchair.	You are the son of a Chinese immigrant who runs a successful fast food business.
You are the son/daughter of the American ambassador to the country where you are now living.	You are the mother of 5 children under 15 years old, you live in a remote Karen village in northern Thailand and you have no safe access to clean water.
You are the owner of a successful import-export company.	You are a homeless young man/woman, 27 years old.
You are a 24-year-old refugee from Myanmar, seeking refuge in northern Thailand after your village has been destroyed.	You are an unemployed university graduate waiting for the first opportunity to work.
You are a very talented 18 year old football player living in a very poor village in the mountains of northern Thailand.	You are a university student from a very poor and remote village, who's received a scholarship, a chance to study and pursue your dream job in town.
You are a very famous actor, who's recently won the most important prize for actors and has attended a celebration in Hollywood.	You are a retired worker from a factory that makes shoes and has a big house in town.
You are a farmer, who lives in a remote village, walking 20 Km each day to sell vegetables at the closest town.	You are 15 and you're the eldest of 6 children. Your parents are asking you to leave school to help them with houseworks and agriculture.
You are a young artist living in a big town, but you're addicted to heroin.	You are an HIV positive, middle-aged prostitute living in a big town.
You are the leader of an emerging political party in the country and you're becoming really popular.	You're an old man/woman living in a small rural Karen village, affected by a severe condition, not able to access health services, due to distance and lack of roads.

*Instructions for teachers

SITUATIONS & EVENTS

ACTIVITY

Read the following situations out aloud. Allow time after reading out each situation for participants to step forward and also to look to see how far they have moved relative to each other.

- You have never encountered any serious financial difficulty.
- You have decent housing with a telephone and television.
- You feel your language, religion and culture are respected in the society where you live.
- You feel that your opinion on social and political issues matters and your views are listened to.
- Other people consult you about different issues.
- You are not afraid of being stopped by the police.
- You know where to turn for advice and help if you need it.
- You have never felt discriminated against because of your origin.
- You have adequate social and medical protection for your needs.
- You can go away on holiday once a year.
- You can invite friends for dinner at home.
- You have an interesting life and you are positive about your future.
- You feel you can study and follow the profession of your choice.
- You are not afraid of being harassed or attacked in the streets, or in the media.
- You can vote in national and local elections.
- You can celebrate the most important religious festivals with your relatives and close friends.
- You can participate in an international seminar abroad.
- You can go to the cinema or the theatre at least once a week.
- You are not afraid for the future of your children.
- You can buy new clothes at least once every three months.
- You feel that your competence is appreciated and respected in the society where you live.
- You can use and benefit from the Internet.
- You are not afraid of the consequences of climate change.

DEBRIEFING & EVALUATION

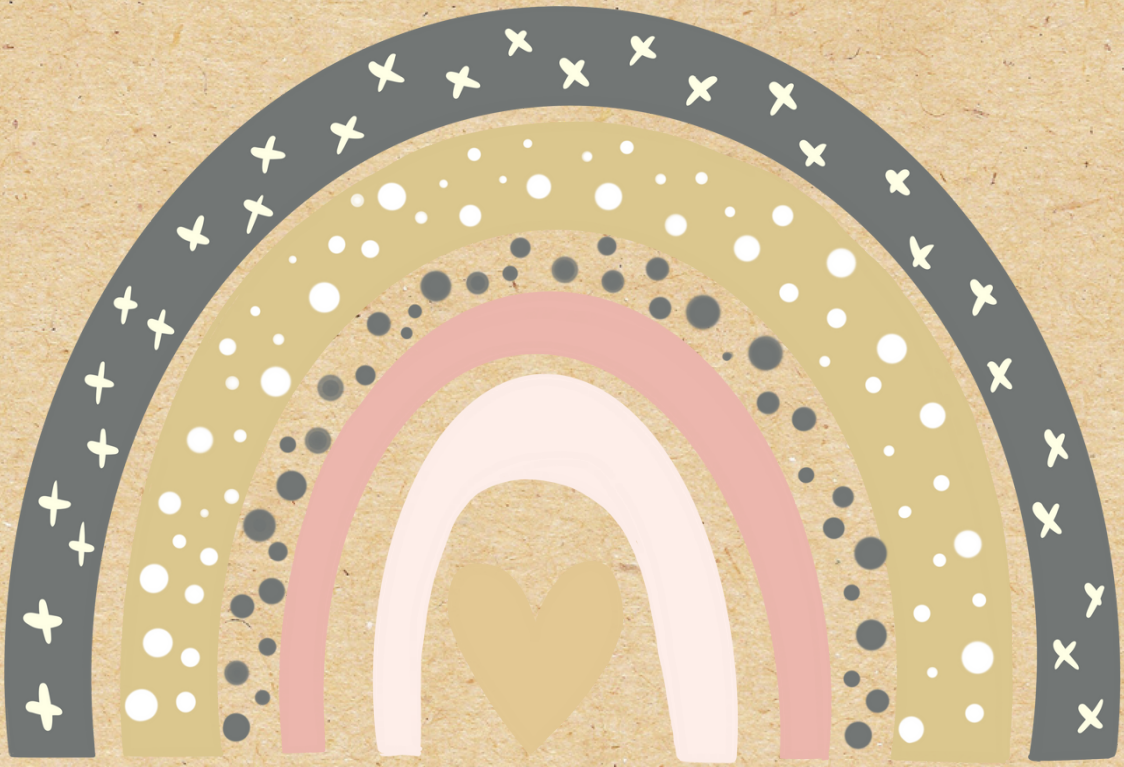
ACTIVITY*

Start by asking participants about what happened and how they feel about the activity and then go on to talk about the issues raised and what they learnt.

- How did people feel stepping forward – or not?
- For those who stepped forward often, at what point did they begin to notice that others were not moving as fast as they were?
- Did anyone feel that there were moments when their basic human rights were being ignored?
- Can people guess each other's roles? (Let people reveal their roles during this part of the discussion)
- How easy or difficult was it to play the different roles? How did they imagine what the person they were playing was like?
- Does the exercise mirror society in some way? How?
- Which human rights are at stake for each of the roles? Could anyone say that their human rights were not being respected or that they did not have access to them?
- What first steps could be taken to address the inequalities in society?



*Instructions for teachers



THANK YOU FOR SUPPORTING KHT!



If you would like to find out more about getting involved,
please contact us via one of the following:

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